PowerTies Consulting Group

A FREE RESOURCE FOR SERVICE MEMBERS · VALUES

V
VALUES

Before You Sign Out

Two free moves that protect real money — for anyone in their last year of service, and for every veteran who never filed.

WHY THIS PAGE EXISTS

Honor — this information is yours by right; nobody should have to buy it. **Sovereignty** — you file your own claim, with your own hands. **Gratitude** — strengths first: you served; this is the paperwork catching up. **Service** — pass this page to one person still in. That's the whole distribution plan.

For anyone in their last year of service — especially the ones who just want out and are skipping every briefing they can sit through — two things are worth doing before you separate, because both are about dates. And with VA disability, dates are money.

Move one — the Intent to File

It is a one-step notice to VA — filed on VA.gov, by phone, or on Form 21-0966 — that says "I am going to file a claim." Filing it **locks your effective date**, which is the date VA pays you back to when your claim is granted. You then have a full year to gather your evidence and file the real claim, and the money still runs from the day you filed the intent.

It costs nothing and takes minutes. Skipping it can cost you months of back pay you will never get back.

Move two — the BDD lane, if you're 90 to 180 days out

BDD — Benefits Delivery at Discharge — lets you file your claim **before** you separate. VA works it while you're transitioning, and your rating and first payments land near the start of civilian life instead of a year into it. Under 90 days there is still a lane. It's just tighter — so the Intent to File matters even more.

Already out, and never filed?

It is not too late, and you are in a lot of company. Plenty of us walked out the gate and filed nothing because we just wanted to be done. An Intent to File submitted **today** protects everything from today forward. File it this week. Then build the claim with your evidence: service records, current diagnoses, anything that ties the condition to your service.

Free help, from people whose job it is

Both moves are free, and both are yours to do yourself. If you want a human beside you, your **county veteran service officer** or an accredited rep from the **DAV, the VFW, or the American Legion** will do this with you — also free. They do it every day.

Nobody needs to pay anybody to file an initial VA claim. If somebody is charging you for that part, ask them some hard questions.

> **THE SHORT VERSION**
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> File an **Intent to File** — VA.gov, by phone, or Form 21-0966. Minutes, free, locks your date for a full year.
>
> 90–180 days out? File the claim itself through the **BDD lane** before you separate.
>
> Want a human? Your county service officer or a DAV / VFW / Legion rep — free, accredited, daily.
>
> Already out? The Intent to File still works, starting today.

I am out a long time now, and I keep meeting veterans years past separation who never filed any of it because they just wanted to be done. I understand that completely. File the intent anyway. Future you — rating in hand and back pay done right — will be glad the paperwork took an afternoon.

Best,
Keith
PowerTies Consulting Group

Prepared by PowerTies Consulting Group, a veteran-owned business, as a public service. This sheet is general information, not benefits advice — VA.gov and accredited veteran service officers are the authority on your specific case. Share it freely.